

video from your camera to your PC, if the camera supports the Video for Windows capture driver—find out in its documentation. VirtualDub is a great tool to process and encode video from your camera, but it comes up short if you need to edit your movie in true film-editor fashion.

To cut up and edit movies, you need to use Kino, one of the most popular non-linear editing (NLE) tools for Linux. It lets you break up your movie into scenes, stitch movies together, add special effects and a lot more. It can even capture video from a FireWire-based camera.

Like all video editing tools, it takes a bit of tinkering to get used to Kino, but once that's done, working with it is quite pleasant.

A Little Make-up

Once you've finished editing your movie, you might want to consider a bit of touching up: Kino won't help you much if you have to make changes to single frames, or if you want to try your hand at rotoscoping, a technique where you draw on each individual frame to convey the impression that you've animated something very well. Think of it as a primitive version of motion capture. If you want to edit individual frames, you need to turn to CinePaint.



CinePaint—it's The GIMP for movies!

CinePaint's former name—Film GIMP—should serve as a hint to what it does. The program supports all major video formats, including high-definition formats like Kodak's Cineon and ILM and NVIDIA's OpenEXR. The interface looks just like that of The GIMP, so if you've used The GIMP before, you shouldn't have any problems. Use CinePaint to make corrections in frames that didn't come out too good, add titles to your movies if you're not satisfied with Kino's capabilities in that department, or add your own weird animations—but remember that working on individual frames can be as exhausting as it is rewarding.

Tell The World!

When your movie is finally done, you'll need a good video encoder to be able to inflict it upon the masses. If you want to make your own holiday DVD, complete with menus, use DVD-Styler. For more advanced encoding features, there's AVIDemux, which also doubles up as a DVD authoring tool when extended with software like dvdauthor.

If YouTube is your chosen route to fame, then you don't have to worry much—as long as you encode your movie to be less than 100 MB and in a file format like AVI or MPEG, it'll get converted by YouTube once you upload it.

The last step is to e-mail your friends and tell them to e-mail their friends about your new creation! (The open source tools for that would be Firefox or Thunderbird, but you already know that). ☐

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